

some fondness. "Despite what happened at the Olympics, 2021 was a great year for me. I had a lot of 90m throws and I was very consistent at that mark. I did find out the hard way that not every surface was meant for me but if I could conserve the kind of form that I was in, I'd wish that I could bring that to 2024 as well," he says.

There have been positive signs. A few weeks back, Vetter posted on Instagram, a training throw from his camp in South Africa. Without a running start and starting only from the crossovers stage of his run-up, Vetter threw what was estimated in the comments section as 80m.

Learning to step back

Despite those flashes of promise, there's always the ever-looming threat of injury. Even as his shoulder has recovered, in recent weeks Vetter felt some trouble with his throwing elbow. While some of his compatriots have already started their throwing season, Vetter will only return to competition in May at home in

Lesson learnt: "The most significant thing I learned was how to treat my body with a little more respect" — Vetter. GETTY IMAGES

THE DIAGNOSIS AND TREATMENT OF HIS INJURY DON'T GUARANTEE A SMOOTH ROAD AHEAD. THOUGH IT CAN BE MANAGED WITH PHYSIOTHERAPY, IT IS A RECURRING ONE

Offenberg.

While it's not what he had planned originally, Vetter has learned to take a step back. "All in all, I'm feeling pretty good. From a strength perspective, I'm not very far off from where I was in 2021. I had a really good training camp in South Africa in the winter. There are some exercises in the gym where I'm even stronger. I actually wanted to start my season in February or March but I picked a slight muscle tear in January. After I treated that, I had some issues with my elbow last month. I've done a lot of treatment to get it fixed again," he says.

While it might be frustrating that he can't head back to the field and just throw, Vetter's learned over the past couple of seasons that sometimes his own ambition can be a stumbling block. "The most significant thing I learned was how to treat my body with a little more respect. I was doing a lot of bad technical things in training and I was getting away with it. I've learned to recognise where I might be starting an injury. When that happens, I know now that I can't throw anymore. I have to find the problem, solve the issue, and only then restart throwing. It's something that can be frustrating because you want to throw but I know that it's most important to throw when I am fully fit and pain-free," he says.

Even as he waits to make his return, Vetter has seen the international field move ahead. Some of that is inevitable. He explains this by way of Germany's own fortunes in the javelin throw. "You always will have new players coming up. There was a time when Germany had a lot of really good throwers (Vetter, Thomas Rohler, and Andreas Hoffman were all throwing over 90m simultaneously back